Selection Sort Research Report

Executive Summary

more to come

History

Selection Sort is one of the oldest sorting algorithms in Computer Science. Because of its simplicity, there is no known original author or documented first-use of the algorithm.

Use Cases

While not often used as a general purpose sorting algorithm in modern computing today, Selection Sort does still have its uses in both education and industry. Due to the inherent simplicity of the algorithm, it is still widely used in Computer Science education. While not as fast as other more modern sorting algorithms in terms of time-complexity, it still has a real-world use on certain embedded systems that have very expensive memory read/write operations. Because the values in the list to be sorted can only ever be moved (swapped) a maximum of **one time** by the sorting operation, this gives Selection Sort an $O(n)$ time complexity it terms of swap operations.

Comparison to Other Sorting Algorithms

To illustrate the unique value of Selection Sort when compared to other sorting algorithms, we must look at the Worst Case Time Complexity **specifically for Swap Operations**:

Sorting Algorithm	**Worst Case (For Swap Operations)**
Selection Sort	$O(n)$
Bubble Sort	$O(n^2)$
Recursive Bubble Sort	$O(n^2)$
Quicksort	$O(nlogn)$
Insertion Sort	$O(n^2)$
Bucket Sort	N/A - not an in-place sort
Radix Sort	N/A - not an in-place sort
Count Sort	N/A - not an in-place sort
Heap Sort	$O(nlogn)$
Tree Sort	N/A - not an in-place sort
Shell Sort	$O(n^2)$
TimSort	N/A - not an in-place sort

Algorithm

Selection Sort

1. Iterate through the list `LIST` while storing the current index as `CURRENT`.
2. Store the value of the `CURRENT` index in `TEMP`

   `TEMP = LIST[CURRENT]`
3. Iterate through the remaining items in the list to find the lowest value and store the index of that item as `LOWEST_IDX`
4. If the current item does NOT have the lowest value of the remaining items, then swap the two values
   1. Move the value of the item at `LOWEST_IDX` to the item at `CURRENT`

      `LIST[CURRENT] = LIST[LOWEST_IDX]`
   2. Move the value `TEMP` to the item at `LOWEST_IDX`

      `LIST[LOWEST_IDX] = TEMP`

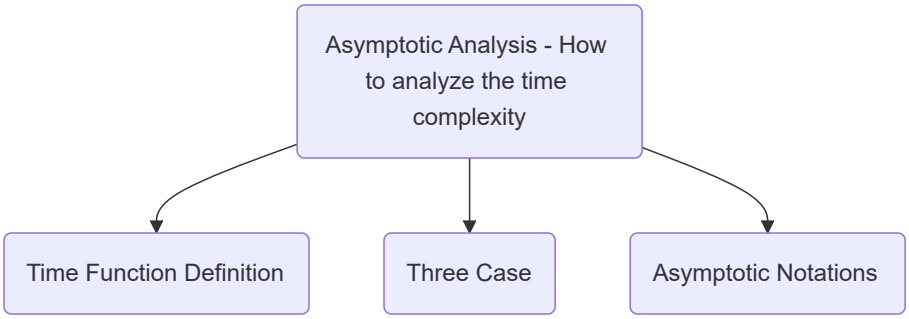
Pseudocode

```
for CURRENT from 0 to length(LIST) do
    TEMP <- LIST[CURRENT]
    LOWEST_IDX <- CURRENT
    for SEARCH from CURRENT to length(LIST) do
        if LIST[SEARCH] < LIST[LOWEST_IDX] then
            LOWEST_IDX <- SEARCH
        endif
    endfor
    if LOWEST_IDX != CURRENT then
        LIST[CURRENT] <- LIST[LOWEST_IDX]
        LIST[LOWEST_IDX] <- TEMP
    endif
endfor
```

Implementation Example (Python)

```python
def selection_sort():
    for c in range(len(LIST)):
        tmp = LIST[c]
        lowest_idx = c
        for s in range(c, len(LIST)):
            if LIST[s] < LIST[lowest_idx]:
                lowest_idx = s
        if lowest_idx != c:
            LIST[c] = LIST[lowest_idx]
            LIST[lowest_idx] = tmp
```

Asymptotic Analysis



Time Function Definition

```
void T(int n[]) {                           // T(n)
    int i, j, tmp, lowest_idx;              // 4
    for (i = 0; i < sizeof(n); i++) {       // n + 1
        tmp = n[i];                         // n
        lowest_idx = i;                     // n
        for (j = i; j < sizeof(n); j++)     // n * (n + 1)
            if (n[j] < n[lowest_idx])       // n * n
                lowest_idx = j;             // n * n
        if (lowest_idx != i) {              // n
            l[i] = l[lowest_idx];           // n
            l[lowest_idx] = tmp;            // n
        }
    }
}
```

$T(n) = 4 + (n+1) + n + n + (n * (n+1)) + n^2 + n^2 + n + n + n$

$T(n) = 3n^2 + 7n + 5$

Asymptotic Analysis Rule #1

(keeping only term with highest degree)

$T(n) = 3n^2$

Asymptotic Analysis Rule #2

(ignore constants)

$T(n) = n^2$

Three Cases

Worst Case

The worst case for time complexity for this algorithm is when **the list is sorted, but in reverse order**. This will require moving every element. However, no matter if all the elements are moved or none of them are moved, the time complexity is $O(n^2)$ because of comparison operations.

$T(n) = 4 + (n+1) + n + n + (n * (n+1)) + n^2 + n^2 + n + n + n$

$T(n) = 3n^2 + 7n + 5$

$T(n) = 3n^2$

$T(n) = n^2$

See Big O Below

Best Case

The best case for Time Complexity for this algorithm is when **the list is already sorted**.
This will not require moving any elements. However the time complexity is still $O(n^2)$ because of comparison operations.

$T(n) = 4 + (n+1) + n + n + (n * (n+1)) + n^2 + n$

$T(n) = 2n^2 + 5n + 5$

$T(n) = 2n^2$

$T(n) = n^2$

See Big Omega

Average Case

The average case for Time Complexity for this algorithm is when **the list is unsorted in such a way that half of items must move**. The time complexity will always be $O(n^2)$ because of the comparison operations.

$T(n) = 4 + (n+1) + n + n + (n * (n+1)) + n^2 + \frac{n^2}{2} + n + \frac{n}{2} + \frac{n}{2}$

$T(n) = \frac{7n^2}{2} + 6n + 5$

$T(n) = \frac{7n^2}{2}$

$T(n) = n^2$

See Big Theta

Asymptotic Notations

Time Complexity Key:

> **Note**
>
> $1 < logn < \sqrt{n} < n < \cdots < n^2 < n^3 < \cdots < 2^n < 3^n < \cdots < n^n$

Big O

Worst Case: Reverse Sorted List

> **Tip**
>
> The function $f(n) = O(g(n)) \iff \exists$ two Constants C and k such that:
> $f(n) <= C \cdot g(n) \quad \forall n >= k$

$n^2 <= C \cdot g(n) \quad \forall n >= 1$
$n^2 <= n^2$ where C =1 and $g(n) = n^2$

From the definition $n^2 = O(n^2)$

Big Omega

Best Case: Sorted List

> **Tip**
>
> The function $f(n) = \Omega(g(n)) \iff \exists$ two Constants C and k such that:
> $f(n) >= C \cdot g(n) \quad \forall n >= k$

$n^2 >= C \cdot g(n) \quad \forall n >= 1$
$n^2 >= n^2$ where C =1 and $g(n) = n^2$

From the definition $n^2 = \Omega(n^2)$

Big Theta

Average Case: Unsorted List

> **Tip**
>
> The function $f(n) = \Theta(g(n)) \iff \exists$ three Constants C_1, C_2, and k such that:
> $C_1 \cdot g(n) <= f(n) <= C_2 \cdot g(n) \quad \forall n >= k$

$C_1 \cdot g(n) <= n^2 <= C_2 \cdot g(n)$

$n^2 <= n^2 <= n^2 \quad \forall n >= 1$ where $C_1 = 1, C_2 = 1$ and $g(n) = n^2$

Based on the definition $n^2 = \Theta(n^2)$

Conclusion

The Selection Sort Algorithm has an *exact bound* since $\Omega(n^2)$, $\Theta(n^2)$, and $O(n^2)$. Therefore, the time complexity is **quadratic** by definition.